



Decisive: Lando Norris (in black) proved to be the consistency factor McLaren needed. GETTY IMAGES

with only one performing car: that of frontrunner Verstappen. Even a resurgent Ferrari couldn't dampen its dream of reclaiming the accolade last won in 1998, despite the Italian team fighting to the very end.

Fighting Ferrari

A deficit of 21 points proved to be a few too many for Ferrari, but both its drivers, Carlos Sainz and Charles Leclerc, pushed until the final lap before settling for a runner-up spot. They rounded off the podium spots in second and third place, respectively, a comparatively strong result considering their shaky start.

Leclerc drove a brilliant race, arguably one of his best, making a staggering 16 moves from 19th place to finish P3. Ahead of him was Sainz, who couldn't keep up with the more

competitive car of Norris but ensured he would bid farewell to the Prancing Horse in fitting fashion — on the podium for them one last time.

The Spaniard was already seen in the Williams the very next day for post-season testing, putting in laps ahead of his new journey. While some will exit the paddock, Sainz is among a few who are switching garages, including seven-time World Champion Lewis Hamilton (**below**), who took fourth after coming through from 16th. Passing the other Mercedes on the final lap, Hamilton had his last hurrah with the Silver



Arrows as he prepares to get behind the wheel of the Ferrari in 2025.

One last 'Hammer' time

After 12 years with Mercedes, which saw Hamilton win six titles and the team eight, he begins a new chapter in his historic Formula One career with one of its fiercest competitors. It was the end of a brilliant partnership that witnessed a period of domination during which the Brit broke numerous records en route to taking the team to the top.

However, after the heartbreaking 2021 season, the Brackley-based unit hasn't been the same. It couldn't deliver a competitive car, causing its drivers, Hamilton and George Russell, to struggle in the midfield. A lone win for the latter in 2022 was the only major achievement during a tough two-year spell. But 2024 saw glimpses of hope for

both the team — with four P1 finishes — and Hamilton, who stood atop the podium after a 945-day wait.

To win at Silverstone, in his backyard, for a record ninth time could have been the best moment for Hamilton to rediscover his groove, but his car didn't cooperate. Another victory was handed to him in Belgium after his teammate's disqualification, but it wasn't enough for the 39-year-old to hold on for another year, hoping for positive changes as new regulations come into play in 2026.

Opting to wear scarlet red next year, Hamilton will be in search of an eighth world title in a field that unleashed its true potential this time around — there were seven different race winners, each securing at least two victories for the first time in the sport's history. Adding to Hamilton's challenges will be the entry of a handful of rookie drivers, including Kimi Andrea Antonelli, who will take his seat.

Up for new challenges

If the season provided any insight into what's in store for next year, it is that defending champions Verstappen and McLaren will have their task cut out. The Dutchman, who was undoubtedly the best of the lot, claiming his fourth successive title, will once again find a few familiar faces and some new ones in his rear-view mirror. McLaren, too, will be well aware of the battles ahead. All 10 teams will have one last chance to make the most of the current rules before they start from scratch in 2026, with significant alterations to be made to the cars and possibly the grid itself (Cadillac reached an agreement "in principle" to enter the grid in 2026).

A great deal is set to change in the upcoming calendar year and the one that follows, but one enduring constant remains: the long three-month wait before the next season is flagged off.



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